Chamberlain. ‘The musket was deliberately raised, the trigger pulled, and happy was he who fell dead. These horrible murders (for such alone must they be in the eyes of God) were truly wicked . . . This is one of the most beautiful valleys in Affghanistan, but we left it a scene of desolation; the Hindustanis being so exasperated against the Affghans, they can never spare anything they can destroy, and all the forts and places within reach were soon on fire.’[52]

Nott’s chaplain, the Rev. I. N. Allen, was even more shocked and wrote that rarely had a clergyman had to witness such scenes. ‘Every door was forced,’ he wrote, ‘every man that could be found was slaughtered, they were pursued from yard to yard, from tower to tower, and very few escaped . . . One door, which they refused to open upon summons, was blown in by a six pounder, and every soul bayoneted.’[53] One soldier who visited the village fort the following day described seeing ‘about 100 dead bodies lying about, and six or eight children were found roasted to a cinder. They had been concealed beneath heaps of chaff which had burned. One woman was the only live thing in the fort. She was sitting, the picture of despair, with her father, brother, husband and children lying dead around her. She had dragged all their bodies to one spot, and seated herself in the midst.’[54]

On arrival outside Ghazni, Nott fought a brief but fierce battle with 12,000 Durranis under the Barakzai Governor of the Province. After the defenders had retired within the walls, Nott then camped just outside the range of the artillery. The following morning the British found the city entirely deserted: the Ghilzai ‘had lost heart’, despite having recently received reinforcements from Kabul under Sultan Jan, and had evacuated during the night. At dawn, Nott blew down the city gates and, as he put it tersely in his official report, ‘I directed the City of Ghuznee, with its citadel and the whole of its work, to be destroyed.’[55]

Only one last ritual remained. Through his reading of James Mill’s *History of India* – a book which Mill famously wrote without ever bothering to visit India, knowing any Indians or learning any Indian languages – Ellenborough had absorbed the entirely false idea that the doors of the tomb of Mahmud of Ghazni (998–1030) were the legendary sandalwood gates that the Sultan had allegedly stolen while looting the great Hindu temple of Somnath in Gujarat. In reality the gates were of a piece with the tomb itself – Seljuk work of the eleventh century – as Rawlinson could immediately see from the Arabic inscriptions on the